

# THE DESPERATE CHALLENGER

LEVELLING CORRUPTION CHARGES AND BY PORTRAYING HIM ANTI-POOR AND ANTI-FARMER, THE CONGRESS IS TRYING HARD TO DENT MODI'S CLEAN IMAGE

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**OPTIMISTIC:** Gujarat Congress chief Bharat Solanki at a rally

**T**welve years back when BJP was seeking to uproot the Congress and lodge the first-ever independent BJP ministry in Gandhinagar, one of its slogans had caught the imagination of the people: "Now, only BJP". Dreaming to uproot Narendra Modi from Gandhinagar in the ongoing battle, the Congress reminds one of the 1995 polls as it harps: "Now, only Congress". The atmosphere in the chamber of Gujarat Congress chief, Bharat Solanki, responsible for imbibing the much-needed killer instinct in party, matches the spirit of that slogan as he goes through a PowerPoint presentation on a strategy to defeat BJP. The strategy is called the cluster-and-wave theory as it concentrates on certain constituencies which also influence neighbouring seats. A confident Solanki says, "Poll results will surprise everybody. We are sit-

ting on a victory, I have no doubt." It's a view that others echo by saying cautiously, "It is a tough battle but we can win it." Most surveys carried out by various agencies give an edge to Modi, but they do not give much credence to the chief minister's claim that he is getting a better public response as compared to 2002 because of his developmental achievements, his tough stand against terrorism and acceptance amongst youth and women.

Significantly, the Congress has chalked out a five-pronged strategy to upstage Modi. On one hand it is trying to dent his personal image by levelling charges of corruption and portraying the Government as belonging to rich businessmen and on the other it is projecting him as anti-poor and anti-farmer. It is also playing the caste card by trying to turn the numerically strong Leuva Patels and Kolis against

BJP by exploiting the divisions in the Sangh Parivar and is also capitalising on the discontent of a section of Hindu saints with Modi. It is wooing government employees, especially teachers, miffed with Modi's tough and result-oriented style of functioning.

The Congress has also picked up the issue of criminal cases against nearly 1.60 lakh farmers for power theft in the last five years. It has promised to withdraw these cases if voted to power. Another handy issue is that of farmers' deaths. The Congress has alleged that nearly 400 farmers have committed suicide in the recent past due to debt, terming BJP's claim to the contrary as a lie. Whether this propaganda will cut ice remains to be seen as the state's agricultural production has gone up in the last five years and the agro sector shows prosperity despite recent losses faced by farmers